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IT MAKES ONE ANGRY TO THINK THAT SOMEONE ELSE IS FORCING HIS BRAND OF HINDUISM ON US AND THE ENTIRE COUNTRY SEEMS TO BE FALLING FOR IT

The very fact that this question is being asked proves that all is not well in this erstwhile secular country of ours. It proves that once again, after the Partition, there is a rupture in our social fabric that perceives the Muslim as the essential "other". Going by the present scenario, it won't be long before we would be asking the same question of the Christians, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains and it can go on. Then I suppose the Hindu mainstream can sit back and relax having shown everyone their true place in this great Hindu nation.

My husband is a Muslim and when we got married, we did not visualise any cause for anxiety rooted in religion. Today, I find myself advising him not to get into an argument with his friends or colleagues over the hounding of M. F. Husain, over the Gujarat pogrom or the Iraq war. It doesn't matter that they have known his views on such issues for the past 30

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years and they didn't mind them then. But now these are the views of a communal Muslim.

We all were very proud and happy that we, as a family, spent more on books than on any other commodity. Today, I die of anxiety every time he buys a book on Islam or Afghanistan or the Iraq war. So what if he has more than a hundred books on Hinduism. We had always believed that we belong to a class where we cannot be harassed unnecessarily by anyone. Today, when my daughter has to go to the police station to report her lost licence or the car has been towed away, I do not allow my husband to go to the police station. Earlier, we loved to watch the looks of incomprehension on people's faces when we told them our different surnames and informed that we

were husband and wife. Today, I always give only my name for all such transactions and always falter when his name is insisted upon.

It may well be a paranoia. But we were not paranoid post-1992, post-Gujarat, or even post-9/11! What happened? Something drastically changed and I can feel it in my bones. My husband insists that he does not feel particularly victimised or alienated. I squirm, when at security check at airports, his documents are scrutinised more closely and he is frisked more

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thoroughly than any of us. I can feel the fear having settled in deep when driving around India Gate at a slow pace, trying to bide time while waiting for our daughter to get free from a party, he joked that he is sure to be arrested as a terrorist plotting an attack if the police see him take yet another round in that area. I can sense the humiliation when in discussions, he is heard asserting that he does not need to prove his patriotism to anyone.

He may not admit it or may be even realise his fear and his gradual alienation, but it makes me both angry and sad. Angry, that someone else is forcing his brand of Hinduism on us to the exclusion of so much else and that I have to live with a sense of guilt for what we as a majority are doing to the minorities. Sad, that the country as a whole seems to be falling for it and that the damage to the psyche is already too deep for total retrieval even if such an attempt were to be made today.

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